# March

**SPECIAL EVENTS**

**PHASES OF THE MOON**

| | Full Moon | New Moon |
|---|---|---|
| **2008** | March 21 | March 7 |
| **2009** | March 11 | March 26 |
| **2010** | March 30 | March 15 |
| **2011** | March 19 | March 4 |
| **2012** | March 8 | March 22 |

**THE PLANETS**

**2008: March 3**
Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.1.

**2009: March 8**
Saturn is at opposition, magnitude 0.5. At midnight, it is visible to the south from northern latitudes and to the north from southern latitudes.

**2010: March 22**
Saturn is at opposition, magnitude 0.5. At midnight, it is visible to the south from northern latitudes and to the north from southern latitudes.

**2011: March 23**
Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.0.

**2012: March 3**
Mars is at opposition, magnitude –1.2. At midnight, it is visible to the south from northern latitudes and to the north from southern latitudes.

**2012: March 5**
Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude –0.3.

**2012: March 27**
Venus is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude –4.3.

**Opposition** and **elongation** are explained on *page 14*



**Leo and Virgo take the place of Orion and Gemini as we herald the start of northern spring and southern fall. On the 20th, or occasionally the 21st, of the month, the Sun crosses the celestial equator as it moves from the southern to the northern celestial sky. Briefly, day and night are of equal length before the northern-hemisphere nights grow shorter and the southern ones longer.**

## NORTHERN LATITUDES

Due south and high in the sky is the distinctive constellation Leo. Its linked stars really do resemble a crouching lion. The curve of his head and the shape of his body are easy to pick out in the sky. Leo looks toward the west, past the faint constellation of Cancer, and on to the winter constellation of Orion as it disappears from view. To the left of Leo are Virgo and its bright star Spica, rising over the eastern horizon. Leo's brightest star, Regulus, marks the start of an outstretched front leg. It is a blue-white star of magnitude 1.4. Through binoculars, a dimmer, wide companion can be seen. Just below the lion's body are five galaxies, all visible with binoculars in good observing conditions.

Ursa Major, the Great Bear, is situated high in the sky above the northern horizon. The bowl of the Big Dipper, formed from seven bright stars in the hindquarters and tail of Ursa Major, is open downward toward Polaris, the Pole Star. Among the stars near the bear's head is M81, one of the easiest galaxies to find with binoculars. It is a spiral galaxy also known as Bode's Galaxy. About one apparent Moon-width away is a second, smaller and fainter galaxy, M82. Cassiopeia, on the opposite side of Polaris, is now almost between Polaris and the horizon, forming a "W" shape.

**Galaxies in Ursa Major**
Galaxies M81 and M82 are in Ursa Major, above the Great Bear's shoulder. With binoculars, the spiral galaxy M81 (right) appears as an elongated patch of light. Cigar-shaped M82 (left) is only visible through a telescope.